



TYRANT, TRAITOR, MURDERER

THE TRIAL OF CHARLES I (1649)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Parliamentary authority

BEFORE

1215 Magna Carta lays out the rights and liberties of English subjects.

1236 The term “parliament” is first used by the Crown, in reference to King Henry III’s council of advisers.

1628 The Petition of Right reasserts the rights laid out in Magna Carta.

AFTER

1660 The monarchy is restored when Charles II returns from exile in France.

1689 The Bill of Rights circumscribes the powers of the monarch and defines the rights of the English Parliament.

1792 King Louis XVI of France is tried by the French National Convention on charges of tyranny and is executed the following year.

Charles I rules as an **absolute monarch** based on the **divine right of kings**.

Parliament argues for a **greater say** in government.

Parliament declares itself the **supreme power** and puts Charles on trial.

The English Civil War sees the **Parliamentarians** defeat the **Royalists**.

The High Court of Justice **finds the king guilty of treason** for waging war on his own people.

The trial of King Charles I was unprecedented in English (and European) history as the first time a monarch faced trial for treason. Charles I subscribed to the traditional doctrine of the divine right of kings, believing that the monarch was chosen by God and was therefore subject to no earthly authority (such as Parliament). He also argued that his power should be

absolute and that only he should be allowed to pass laws. This position put him at odds with Parliament, which at that time was convened or dissolved as the king saw fit but had for many years pushed for greater influence. In 1641, when, against the wishes of Parliament, Charles raised an army to deal with a rebellion in Ireland, it was seen as an affront to Parliament’s power. Events came